

THE BIRTH OF INTEREST

My first awareness of the stock market and the opportunities which changing stock quotations might make possible occurred at a fairly early age. With my father the youngest of five and my mother the youngest of eight, at my birth I had only one surviving grandparent. This may have been one of the reasons why I felt particularly close to my grand-mother. At any rate, I went to see her one afternoon when I was barely out of grammar school. An uncle dropped in to discuss with her his views of business conditions in the year ahead, and how this might affect the stocks she owned. A whole new world opened up to me. By saving some money, I had the right to buy a share in the future profits of any one I might choose among hundreds of the most important business enterprises of the country. If I chose correctly, these profits could be truly exciting. I thought the whole subject of judging what makes a business grow an intriguing one, and here was a game that if I learned to play it properly would by comparison make any other with which I was familiar seem drab, meaningless and unexciting. When my uncle left, my grandmother turned to me and said how sorry she was that he happened to come in when I was there, forcing her to spend time on matters which could not possibly interest me. I told her that, to the contrary, the hour he spent with her had seemed like ten minutes, and that I had just heard something that interested me tremendously. Years later I was to realize how very few were the shares she owned and how extremely superficial were the comments I heard that day, but the interest that was kindled by that conversation has continued all during my life.

With this degree of interest and in a period when most businesses were far less concerned with the legal hazards of dealing with minors than is the case today, I was able to make a few dollars for myself during the roaring bull market of the middle 1920's. I was strongly discouraged from this, however, by my physician father, who felt that it would simply teach me gambling habits. This was unlikely, as I am not by nature inclined to take chances merely for the sake of taking chances, which is the nature of gambling. On the other hand, as I look back upon it, my tiny scale stock activities of that period taught me almost nothing of any great value so far as investment policies were concerned.